August 1959 clashes, that Nehru's advisors might use these skirmishes to push him and the entire government further to the "right" i.e. towards a militant anti-China policy and a willingness to accept some degree of American support in this policy. The practical strategic danger such a development posed was that the arc of US bases "encircling" China would be extended through India.'

In the CIA's assessment, Mao and other Chinese leaders believed that elements in the Indian establishment 'particularly those in the Ministry of External Affairs and including General Thimayya, were "rightists" who wanted to exploit the border dispute to help the US "isolate China". On the contrary, Thimayya, as we have seen, was dead against any military adventurism against China, or the deployment of the army in either NEFA or Ladakh. By a process of elimination, this only leaves Mullik and Kaul, as the two hard-nosed hawks on the Indian side who, once having got Nehru to officially endorse the Forward Policy, began to push for and implement an aggressive stand that could not have been matched by the available logistical support on the ground.

In the build-up to the events of October-November 1962, Kaul's ominous presence seems to have been everywhere. As QMG between the second half of 1959 until 1961, it was his responsibility to create the supply lines that would be required to sustain Indian troops in both Ladakh and NEFA. But his cavalier attitude towards logistics combined with Bogey Sen's refusal to step in meant that very few 'warlike' supplies could be ferried to the men who were asked to set up posts in areas that were almost impossible for human habitation.

Kaul's elevation to the post of CGS coincided with Nehru ordering the army to implement the Forward Policy. In the second half of 1961, Kaul told Brigadier D. K. Palit 'that in Ladakh where we are not in occupation of territory we claimed, it was imperative to demonstrate a presence in the empty spaces, even if such forward moves temporarily outran maintenance capabilities at war rates'. Under the umbrella of Mullik's assurance that the Chinese would not react, Kaul's illogical desire to push forward on all fronts created the recipe for a military disaster that few could even begin to imagine.

During the critical Dhola incident on 8 September 1962, Kaul was on leave, holidaying in the Kashmir Valley. The Dhola incident acted as a catalyst for subsequent events. Brigadier Dalvi was stopped from